Just don't tell mum I'm in Thaymor

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/57052006.

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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Minor or Background Relationship(s)

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Original Characters, Grox (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Juliet (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Horde Soldiers (She-Ra), Tung Lashor, Huntara (She-Ra)

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Part 2 of 'For what it's worth?'

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by Franek_Kimono

Summary

The Great Etherian War is not only about the main characters, She-Ra, Prime, and such. This war has no moments of glory, it's a terrible mess, especially for the Rebel soldiers.

This is the second part of the 'For what it's worth' series. The entire series is modeled on actual battles that took place in Bosnia or Croatia in 1991-1995.

The story is based on a fic created by the amazing @Kurt-Angles-Tailbone (They will know my name) :D

(Some characters were added to make AO3 requirements: Huntara and Angela don't occur, Glimmer and Tung Lashor are only mentioned)

If you need clarification on incomprehensible abbreviations, there is a list of abbreviations used at the end of this short one-shot.

Let me know if you like it!

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

- Inspired by They'll Know My Name by Kurt_Angles_Tailbone

In eternal memory of all the victims of the wars in Bosnia and Croatia in 1991-1995

Thaymor, May 12, '92, seat of municipal authorities

Wounded city. This could be another way to describe Thaymor, the largest agglomeration after Brightmoon within the Kingdom of Brightmoon. Before the war, the town was a bustling railway junction and an important administrative center. Every six months, the authorities organized the Great Festival of Light, which gathered spectators from every, even the most distant, kingdom of Etheria. Next to traditional wooden and stone houses, modern, slender buildings were built, fulfilling residential and business roles, new roads, bridges, and parks were built...

And then came the Horde. End of dreams.

Corporal Zey sat, head down, atop a tall concrete skyscraper, or rather, atop the remains of a building. A beautiful, moonless, cool night.

Ehhh, I lived only two hundred meters away...

Every time the gunfire stopped, every time the shots and explosions ceased,

he set out for the same place, the same view of his ruined house.

A sea of rubble everywhere, buildings barely standing, burnt temples,

the City Park was plowed by tanks and bots, gray and burnt...

For a moment he sat in silence, hiding his tears from the other soldiers,

his tears of helplessness before the cruelty.

He had only been in the army for two years, but it felt like decades had passed since he was a happy teenager with a head full of dreams.

Without thinking much, he reached into his uniform pocket for a pack of cigarettes, his only pleasure since arriving in Thaymor a year ago.

Fuck, empty…

Reluctantly rising from his solitude, from his place on this cursed earth,

he slowly walked down to the sharpshooter station.

-Hey, Coj? - he said as kindly as he could, but he couldn't. All this shit had deprived them of any emotion except a sense of emptiness and helplessness.

-What do you want Z?

-Will you gimme one cig? Mine pack empty...

-Ehhh, okay. Let me remind you that you owe me half a frame. Fuck it,

quit smoking, or buy some! Hold.

Zey took one of the five remaining, badly wrinkled and straw-smelling cigarettes, and lit it.

-*Ekhe* Fuck Coj, what is this? It looks like shit and tastes even worse!

-You don't like it, give it back! What do you think, louse, where did I get them? One of the dead bodies of those fucking AHR scumbags had a few packages

in his backpack, so I took…

Zey didn't want to say anything anymore, he just wanted to turn around and go back to his refuge, just to get his mind away from this madness as much as possible.

-Wait Z!-He was stopped by his fucking robber companion,

as devoid of emotions as people on psychotropic drugs.

-Well, what do you want?

-You don't want to, you know... talk a little? We've known each other for over years, we were friends in high school, and recently we haven't even talked for more than five minutes.

Fuck, what can I do, I won't tell him I don't want to, but on the other hand...

I really don't want to talk to anyone...

Ehh, okay!

"What do you want to talk about?" Z said, as dismissively as possible.

-You know... [He paused for a moment to light a cigarette], you know, I wonder what's next? The Horde hasn't given us a fucking

week of respite for the last six months, constant attacks, all this shit, you know what I'm talking about!

And now what?! We have been sitting in these ruins like rats for almost half a month, not even a single shell has fallen on Thaymor! What the fuck is going on here?!

-Does it matter? You know, they also have to regroup their forces.

Believe me, in a few days it will start again...

-If it weren't for the fact that...

A sudden shot, then another, which shattered the window next to them into tiny pieces.

-Fucking sniper! Down, down, now!

Zey, for all his nihilism, fell flat to the ground. He cocked the gun. Coj hid at the back of the room without a wall to reach for his sniper rifle.

-The son of a bitch is probably shooting to the hospital, like last time... Zey!

See where he's shooting from?

The corporal barely raised his head above the rest of the window, only to have his helmet ricocheted. The bullet bounced off the walls and hit the door frame after the burnt-out door.

-Fuck, okay, don't come over there, Z! There are probably two of them.

I won't fucking shoot at them from here! Do you have a walkie-talkie?

"Here," he hissed in deeply hidden horror and then handed him a small, rectangular device, still not very common among AKoB ranks.

-Hello, hello, Eagle-12 to Hippo-4! Please come forward!

-Yes, Warrant Coj?

-Most likely a group of snipers, at least two, from the north-west.

Could you guys fuck around with your H-53s a bit and get their attention?

-Yes Warrant Officer Coj!

A moment of silence, then a furious barrage of fire toward the hills,

very popular among AHR sniper units.

-You see, Z! Grab your rifle, it's time to hunt, you motherfuckers!

The corporal took the sniper rifle in his hands and put the sight to his temple, calibrating it now and then with his hand. After a long moment of silence,

the barrage fire stopped, as did the shots of these criminals.

Something moved on the ruins of the former fire station tower. Shot.

-Congratulations, Zey, you hit the crow!-said Coj, full of irony.

How come you're in a sniper company, heh!

-Shhh!

Hours passed and neither of them even moved,

waiting on full alert to end the life of one of these motherfuckers.

Only when the city woke up, returning back to its strange war life, the warriors lose their strength and lie down on the remains of the burnt sofa, not knowing when they had fallen asleep.

***

-Warrant Officer Coj! Is this how you're on guard duty?! - A stocky, bearded Captain Dean stood in front of the two guards.

Coj stood up almost immediately, hitting his head on a hanging heating pipe, which caused even more chaos in the "guard room".

-No no no! Mr. Captain, all night long...

-You were on guard all night, huh? What about those shooters? While you were on guard, didn't you hear the shots?!

-Captain, we swear, we've been looking for them in the dark all night,

Warrant Coj...

-Shut up, Corporal! What, two days of solitary confinement!

You will hand over the weapon to my adjutant...

But first, you will report to headquarters what this night shooting from our hidden guns was supposed to mean!

You idiot, do you know how much this could cost us?!

-Mr. Captain...

-I finished!

Coj handed over his belt and gun to the sergeant with an incredibly stern face, and then left the room slowly, with his head down.

-Corporal Zey!

-Yes, Captain!

-You will also come with me to the headquarters, for now as a witness!

Fuck, why did so many good people die and this fucking grunt is still here...

The four slowly walked out of the heavily damaged building, heading down Main Avenue to the Headquarters, located in the east of the city.

The psychology is funny, even though they were in no danger, no one was shooting, every one of them automatically lowered his head, ran through dangerous places, and three armed soldiers kept their guns cocked,

ready to shoot at any moment.

Third Tactical Group "Thaymor" Headquarters

Thaymor was a place full of paradoxes, completely incomprehensible to an ordinary person who somehow found himself there.

The western districts and the center looked, to say the least, like Bakhmut.

In this sea of gray, it was hard to find anything that wasn't damaged or destroyed. Burnt barricades, bodies of AHR soldiers lying around for weeks, eaten by rats, the constant stench of burnt, rotting corpses... the stench of death.

The east of the city looked completely different, the Horde managed to partially capture it only once, and the fire in that direction was not very frequent.

Of course, there was still a lack of water and electricity, every eighth building was in ruins, and only stumps remained of the ubiquitous trees.

Still, for the Frontliners, Eastern Thaymor appeared as Janna, as their Mecca.

A few months earlier, AHR rocket fire destroyed the headquarters,

then located in the city center, killing the city's defense commander in the process.

By order of General Juliett, the headquarters of the commanders were moved to the east and the command was taken over by Second Class General Yenna,

who was famous for successfully defending the area around Plumeria.

Yenna, like the commander-in-chief of AKoB, came from an old, pre-war officer school, brave, loyal, but painfully formulaic and static. Despite her initial enthusiasm, Yenna, like the rest of the soldiers, fell into a strong bond of helplessness. From month to

month, from week to week, the desire to expel and defeat the Horde turned into desperate attempts to defend and hold

the stronghold constantly attacked on three sides.

The headquarters was located in the former district court archives,

one of the buildings practically untouched by shelling, apart from the broken door frames.

The ground floor and basements were occupied by shooting posts and small ammunition warehouses. On the first floor, in several rooms, temporary quarters were set up for the TG commander and several closest colonels, while on the second floor, there was a large communications room with a meeting space.

The unimaginable stuffiness coming from the full ashtrays hurt everyone's eyes.

-Colonel Turpa? -The general, with severely bloodshot eyes, muttered over the interactive tactical map, glaring menacingly at several talking officers.

-Yes, General?

-When is Captain Dean scheduled to arrive? I would like to know the motives behind this idiotic firing!

The colonel didn't even have time to answer when there was a knock on the door.

-Come in!

-General Yenna, Captain Dean reports his arrival, along with warrant officer Coj!

-At ease!-Yenna stood up, only to lose her balance and fall into a chair. It was an open secret that the commander liked to resort to alcohol, especially if there were several bottles of 'Dryl Luxussive Vodka' sticking out from under the bed.

-So, Coj, what was it yesterday?! Be brief, my head is hurting.

-General, around 1 a.m. sniper fire began from the Igman hills...

-We already know this, several soldiers were injured, damn it!

Why didn't you shoot, but called our artillerymen?!

-Corporal Zey will confirm that we came under fire ourselves,

we had to improvise!

-You should have retreated and taken better positions, it was against the regulations to call in the artillery for the fuck! Captain Dean also wrote in the report [Yenna put on her glasses and read the document] that, hmmm,

he found you sleeping! What's the excuse?

-Madam General...

-Madam General! Brightmoon is on the line!

-We'll come back to this conversation, Coj! For now, two days of solitary confinement, and pray that this will end! March back! Tukin!

-Yes Sir?

-Put Brightmoon on your main link!

The four saluted and obediently left the building. Captain Dean, his aide-de-camp, and Coj to the right, to the lockup, Zey to the left,

to his solitude...

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-General Yenna to General Juliett!

-General Yenna reporting!

-You know what, it's weird to say this, after all this, but...

But I guess it's over! - Juliett's voice was filled with unspeakable joy.

-I don't understand…

-You've never been very default, I know! During the intervention of the Princess Alliance in the Fright Zone two weeks ago, Hordak was killed...

Fuck, that's why they're not attacking now, but these snipers, I don't understand anything anymore...

Until recently, we didn't know what actually happened and who was in power

in the Horde, but today the Horde announced that he is on the throne...

[A moment of silence, a fucking painful silence]

The Horde is ruled by Catra.

Yenna was filled with fucking anger, a wave of indescribable anger,

barely concealed in a stern, soldierly mask.

-I don't think this is good news, General Juliett! This fucking bitch still won't leave us alone!

-Oh no, on the contrary! The Horde has announced in a special bulletin that they are proposing peace, on terms agreed upon at a conference to be held in the Whispering Woods in a week...

-And we're supposed to believe her? It's Catra… It's Horde…

-I know! I'm more skeptical than Queen Angela, but there's nothing I can do. For now, a ceasefire has been agreed, so as a gesture of our goodwill,

I am ordering your troops to withdraw from West Thaymor. The use of weapons against AHR units is prohibited! Understood?

Yenna bit her lip, hiding her reluctance to accept this order.

-Yes Sir! Checking out!

-One more thing, Yenna! It would be nice if you also attended this conference. We need your exact knowledge about the possible border near Thaymor.

That's all!

-What if they attack Thaymor then?

-I doubt it, the Horde is pretty beaten up after the last action in their capital!

-Yes Sir!

The radio turned off.

It is impossible

It's probably some lie, some dirty game...

What if, then…

This is the end?!

-Tukin!

-Yes, General?

-Connect me instantly to all communications bases within the Tactical Group! Finally some good news...

Yenna would not admit it herself, but after the first moment of doubt, happiness came, so long present in the lives of the defenders of Thaymor.

She cried, she cried with happiness, finally this shit was over...

Yenna turned the inductor crank,

-Attention to all units! Attention to all units!

According to the claims of the AKoB staff and the new AHR authorities,

a peace agreement will be signed in a week, ending the war...

Many of our brothers did not live to see this moment, we cannot forget about them, but don't think about it for now!

The command of the Third Tactical Group prohibits opening fire on AHR soldiers for an indefinite period, and at the same time we announce that after reaching a peace agreement, we will leave Thaymor as soon as possible.

As of today, the headquarters is exempting most soldiers from performing official duties for 24 hours, at the same time we inform you that you are still subject to military courts and military legislation!

Long live the Rebellion! Long live AKoB! Long live Queen Angela!

The call ended and Yenna sank into her chair.

-All officers, except liaison officers, can leave!

All these soldiers, civilians, what is it all for?!

-Tukin!

-Yes, General?

-Bring me a bottle... And then go away, you're free!

-Yes, General!

Light flashes in the dark...

Zey walked through the empty streets, full of rubble and remains of bots, constantly tripping over numerous corpses of soldiers from both sides.

This doesn't impress him.

Nothing impresses him anymore...

Suddenly there was complete silence in the city, almost painful and palpable.

Half a minute, there was a veritable explosion of screams, and shots in the air, singing with joy, a moment that each of them had been waiting for a long, too long time...

No, don't give a damn about that...

-Hey you! What's your name? - The corporal pointed to the private who was crying with happiness.

-Private Treek, 86th Light Infantry Battalion.

-What's going on here?!

-You don't know anything?! End of the war, the Horde plans to sign peace!!

No, no, no, impossible, Zey, wake up!

-AHHHHHHHH, Fuck YEAH!

Without thinking, Zey lunged at the small, bull-headed private, almost crushing him in his grasp.

Although they were on the street, they started dancing with happiness

and kissing each other on the cheeks...

So this is what the end of it all looks like, a little... weird

-Treek! Come quickly! The vodka is already cooling! -An unknown voice called from the basement of the former "Snowflake" café.

-I'm on my way! Wait a moment...

Private started running as if his shoes were on fire, only to stop several meters away. He's back.

-Mr. Corporal...

-Corporal Zey, 49th Special Marksman Unit, I forgot to introduce myself!

-Corporal Zey, don't you have anything to do? There will be room for one more!

Ehhh, another dilemma, go 'there' or stay with these fuckers! Well, it doesn't matter anyway, I'll leave soon anyway! And is it worth it? Fuck!

-Private Trek, I'd like to, but I have to stand guard at night, I can't...

-You really don't know anything, ha! These idiots in the headquarters dismissed almost everyone from duty for 24 hours and ordered us to withdraw from West Thaymor!

This private's enthusiasm is downright fucking terrifying!

-Then I'd love to!

-Welcome, welcome! They indeed shot through our radio a month ago,

but we found an undamaged guitar!

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The feast in the dirty, blackened cellars, which began before noon, continued slowly.

Getting to know Treek's companions, the first glasses, then the next ones. No more alcohol, looking for more bottles in the ruins. Dozens of smoked, crappy, cheap cigarettes, the smell of sweat and dirt.

After a few hours, the heavily inebriated soldiers took an old wooden guitar out of its case.

-Gntlmens, can anyne plye?!- asked Lieutenant Yrsin, powerful, stern, always tough, now laughing and happy, like a little child.

-ME!!!- An unknown-by-name sergeant stood up from the depths of the corridor and approached with unsteady steps.

A moment of silence, then a terrible creaking sound, resembling the sound of a cat being murdered rather than music.

-Sit down, you fucking one-Dinar musician!

-Who the fuck said that?!- The sergeant pulled out his gun, but he was so drunk that when trying to aim it at the critic of his art, he fell over and broke his chair.

-Fucking calm! I can play... - Said someone with a cigarette between his teeth.

-New?

-Zey?

-Oke, Crporal, show me wat ju mean! - The lieutenant smiled warmly, handing him the case.

Zey probably took the guitar and fretboard.

After all, before all this went to shit, I was learning to play guitar a little...

-What should we play, dear audience? - He said sarcastically.

-I know! I know! 'Hordak has only got one ball'!

-You need a piano for that, you idiot!

-Maybe 'Aj Karmela'?

-Do you want them not to be accused of promoting socialism? All these nobles couldn't stand it! Besides, I don't know the southern language...

I have a better idea!

Zey sat down on a broken stool, put out his cigarette, and straightened his lush black hair. Silence, then the first sounds of strings.

'Hello my dearest, how are you?

The roads at home must be covered by greenery…

Rockets are falling in Igman's dawn sky,

Just don't tell Mom I'm in Thaymor.

Grenades are falling in Igman's dawn sky,

Just don't tell Mom I'm in Thaymor!

Last night a Hordian bastard hit our post,

Our commander is dead, he will be coming home in the "black sack"...

It just makes me want to curse this bloody war,

Just don't tell Mom I'm in Thaymor.

It just makes me want to curse this bloody war,

Just don't tell Mom I'm in Thaymor.

Saturday is coming, we'll wash our clothes and forget about war,

Everything smells of sweat and no one is sleeping, it was a difficult battle.

Three of us didn't make it back, it makes me want to cry,

Just don't tell Mom I'm in Thaymor.

Three of us didn't make it back, it makes me want to cry,

Just don't tell Mom I'm in Thaymor…'

Complete silence, silence ringing in your ears.

Silent, deeply hidden tears of soldiers, barely audible sobbing, the sound of successive rounds of vodka, subsequent cigarettes being lit.

-If you don't want me to continue playing...

-No!-The lieutenant stood up, pretending that his face wasn't full of tears.

-We need it!

Zey didn't say anything else, he just grabbed the strings.

‘A light flashes in the dark...

Brother, let's smoke in silence

I hear your voice

Painfully familiar to me.

Warm up some tea, let's drive away the drunkenness,

Today was a hard day,

We've taken the hill

The black wolf whines in pain!”

Zey paused only to remember the lyrics and to drown his sorrows in a glass.

“We are not puppies, we are the dogs of war

The battalion commander said: "Forward, my sons!"

You all went through: fire and water,

Copper and pipes…

The motor roared, the lead sprayed,

Everything is alien here,

Even the forest,

But we crawled forward

Gritting our teeth in anger.

What I would give for an hour at home,

To hear again: "My love,

Don't leave, stay with me

A bit longer…"

Snowy peaks in the distance

The Halmor ridge is covered in dust,

Through it lies my home

My road…”

Zey couldn't play anymore, his body was shaking, and he could barely keep from crying.

-I don't remember more... I think I have to go back to my camp. Gentlemen,

we have to do this again!

-I agree! You have real talent, dude!

-Gentlemen, it was great, I hope it was great for you too, I have to go...

Zey jumped out like an arrow from the basement, or rather like a drunken arrow.

As he walked towards his quarters, he cried, he cried all the way.

After the first explosion of joy, the feeling of hopelessness and sadness returned.

Cry, sob.

We are trash to those noble asses from Brightmoon, what happened here will never be undone...

What's the point of all this? Rytel, Quale, Wekir, Turr, Etuk…

They're gone, lucky people! At least they sleep peacefully in their graves!

Corporal Zey entered the barracks, already somewhat calmed down after the explosion, to see his old friend superior there, surrounded by several soldiers from his unit.

-What, Zey? Won't you have a drink with us?

Fright Zone, May 13, '92

A small, two-seater, slightly outdated T469 off-roader rolled into the city of Fright Zone, disappearing among the tall towers and chimneys of this cursed place.

Inside the vehicle sat two officers, proudly wearing Third Corps badges and insignia resembling the *Gorani* flag.

The speed and recklessness of the driver indicated that he was in a hurry or had previously consumed alcohol.

-Ljubo, slow the fuck down!

The older, bearded officer with a beret on his forehead clearly regretted giving the steering wheel to his brother.

Captain Ljubiša responded only with a snort and pressing the gas pedal to the floor.

Driving well over a hundred kilometers per hour (if the off-road vehicle could travel two hundred, Ljubo would probably take advantage of it) ended very quickly. Control point.

-Sergeant Gray, Checkpoint 22! I'll ask for the documents!

[The poor sergeant had to read those difficult names out loud to the Gorani]

Brigadier General Atif Hala-simo-vic?-The guard could barely spell it.

-Yes, it's me. -He said with a slight sarcasm.

-Captain, oh fuck... Captain Ljubi, Ljubisa Filips?

-Filipović! But it's a cool nickname, often used in AHR.

[Captain smirked at the poor guard]

-Yes, I'm sorry, Captain. Purpose of the trip, General?

-None of your business, all I can say is that they are expecting us at Hordak's Asylum. Is that enough?!

-Yes, sir! Open the barrier!

As soon as the heavy steel pole was lifted, the small off-road vehicle was speeding through the empty, concrete streets of the Fright Zone again.

The sound of a lighter and smoke straight from the lungs of the commander of the 301st Brigade.

-By the way, Atif, fuck...

-Yeah?

-Could you please not smoke in my car? Then I have to clean it!

-He said to a guy who smokes himself...

-But not in the fucking car!-The captain reached out and grabbed the senior officer's cigarette, then threw it out the window.

-For now, watch the road, no not your lungs! Here to the right!

-Yes, sir, 'I am an important general, so I can rule myself'!

-If you weren't driving, then... slow down the fuck!

The car stopped just before the electric, greenish protective shield.

A tall, athletic security officer stood in front of them.

Atif stood up and hit the captain on the head.

-That's for the 'general'!-a second blow to the back of the head

-And that's because you don't look at the road!

-But I slowed down!

-Umm, gentlemen? Lieutenant Burgund reports,

Security Station No. 3. Can I ask for your documents?

- Please, just don't bother reading them, another guard who will mutilate our language... - Ljubiša replied maliciously.

-Mr. General, Mr. Captain, for safety reasons, please deposit your weapons and belts and undergo an X-ray check. The car will be reparked. Here are the IDs to open all the doors.

The officers obediently submitted to the inspection and then set off on foot to the headquarters.

-Do you think it's important, brother?

-If it weren't for that, she wouldn't have pulled us from the front, and similarly, she wouldn't have summoned us individually, idiot!

-Could you at least stop insulting me for five minutes?!

-Put yourself in my situation, it's very difficult!-Atif's ironic smile drove Ljubo to a state of near madness.

-If you weren't higher in charge, I would have punched you!

-Let's calm down for now, someone else will shout at us!

***

The AHR headquarters looked completely different than most command posts on Etheria. A clean, tidy room, with a special raised, black and red seat-throne at the end of the room, a giant interactive map in the middle, tables, and seats for the other commanders on the sides.

The room was illuminated by numerous lamps illuminating in a greenish color.

What caught your eye was a huge red sign with a clear message:

“Smoking and drinking alcohol are strictly prohibited!'

Catra sat on the throne, surrounded by Cobalt, Scorpia, and Wrong Kyle.

The appearance of this entire entourage was majestic and, ironically,

at the same time slightly grotesque.

Right next to him, on a specially prepared seat, was Colonel Grox.

-Commander Catra! General Atif Halasimović and Captain Ljubiša Filipović announce their arrival!

-Scorpia, Cobalt, Wrong Kyle... Leave.

-Yes Sir!

Behind the Commander's entourage, the doors barely had time to close and the meeting took on a slightly less formal tone.

-Sit down, gentlemen, as you may have guessed, I didn't call you for anything... -Catra began in her hoarse, magnetic voice. A voice that made any opposition impossible. Catra continued her monologue.

-If you don't know yet, we have decided to sign a peace agreement with the Rebellion. However, it is always better to get insurance, 'just in case'.

Following the arrangements we made with the princesses [the word 'princesses' contained so much contempt that if contempt could kill, we would all drop dead], all important officers of the AHR, AKoB, SA, etc. are expected to come and take part in the talks. Do you see what I mean?

-I guess so, Commander Catra.

-Despite everything, sometimes I doubt your intelligence,

so to clear up any misunderstandings…

Catra turned on the map, with Horde units marked.

-General Atif, for the duration of the conference, you will be given temporary command of the 501st, 502nd, 515th, and 505th brigades.

-Yes, Commander Catra!

-Ljubo, first of all, change your name, no normal person can pronounce it! Secondly, you will be given temporary command of the 301st Brigade.

Additionally, I assigned you the 103rd Gendarmerie Brigade.

You are directly subject to your brother's orders.

-Yes Commander!

-Colonel Grox, in addition to commanding the 511th Brigade, you will also command the forces coming from the Sixth Corps. Understood?

-Yes Commander!

-You [here she pointed to adoptive brothers],

you will set out with full powers and take up a position northwest of Thaymor. Grox, you will attack from the south, from Drumar. Only on my personal orders will you attack the Rebellion and take both of these cities by surprise. General Atif, you should attack with your strongest units from the west, these idiots withdrew from them as a gesture of 'goodwill'. Ljubo, your brigades will attack from the north, but only when AKoB troops focus on Atif's brigades.

You will enter the center and you will encircle the brigades fighting against Atif. The mission is particularly difficult, so you will receive an additional battalion of new-generation bots.

Forces commanded by me personally will attack from the northeast, but this will happen only when I return from the Peace Conference. Understood?!

-Yes Commander Catra!

-We'll push them south, that's where you come in, Grox. You will attack the defeated Rebel forces from the south, and then come with me

and Grizzlor towards Drumar. This city is equally important.

You gentlemen at that time you will relinquish command of the Force to Captain Lonnie and return to Dryl.

The entire operation to capture the city of Thaymor should last no longer than twelve hours. The action is codenamed 'Sun'.

I repeat that any attack is to take place only after I give the order, only by me. In other cases, any form of aggression towards these scum is prohibited. Understood?

All members of the council nodded.

-Any questions? I'm listening Ljubo...

-When should we prepare the brigades for attack?

-Immediately, but for now, stay several kilometers away from Thaymor, it will lull their vigilance. Something else? All right. Then you can leave, except for you, Ljubo.

The officers obediently saluted and headed for the exit.

-And Atif, one more thing!

-Yes, Commander Catra?

-I'm glad that this sign helped you break the habit of smoking here.-She said in a voice full of malice and irony.

The door closed and Catra stood over the map.

-Captain, you're probably wondering why I told you to stay.

-Commander Catra, I have some suspicions...

-I prefer certainty to suspicion, it doesn't matter! In short, the AKoB troops in the city, according to our intel, are currently busy drinking and dreaming. They do not have sufficiently well-manned

security posts, weak and few patrols. Do you understand now? - Filipović nodded affirmatively.

-When should I send my unit?-He replied firmly.

-Preferably just before the negotiations start, of course, they have to go without you, you are needed in the north of Thaymor. They have to place explosives under bridges, railway lines, radio antennas, etc. Force Captain Lonnie will give you a list of all the points necessary for destruction. The objects are to be blown up only after my personal order. The operation is kept in the strictest secrecy, even Atif is not supposed to know about it. Understood?

-Yes, Commander Catra!

-That's all, you can leave.

The young, thin officer, with obvious madness in his eyes, saluted loudly and walked away into the shadow of the corridor.

Catra looked at the map, at the location of the AHR units, and the spy data that gave relatively accurate coordinates of the Rebel units.

Everything is going like clockwork.

Buried Hope

The days in Thaymor passed at a slow, slightly melancholic pace.

Officers and ordinary soldiers, still attached to their posts and units, constantly dreamed about what would happen in a few days. End of the war, disbandment of the brigade, return to a small shop as a watchmaker, return to the countryside to spend

the rest of his life farming on his two-hectare farm, return to wife, girlfriend, husband, boyfriend, children, parents, siblings, grandparents...

If only everyone had somewhere to return to, other than a pile of

rubble and a makeshift cemetery.

This is obvious, but it is worth mentioning again:

'war is a terrible bitch'.

Zey sat in his solitude again, theoretically on duty as a sentinel. In particular,

he was to guard the portable radio communications point with Brightmoon from a distance. In fact, the hangover and feeling of emptiness made it impossible to perform this function.

The conference should start soon...

Warrant Coj had a great talent for finding all sorts of trinkets and devices in the ruins of the Wounded City.

While returning from one of the events, he came across the radio in almost perfect condition. A few faults needed to be repaired and the radio was working, making guests from other units very happy.

-What?

-Yeah? What, are you feeling dry after yesterday? - He said with a malicious smile.

-No, it's not that... What... what are you going to do when... once this is over?

-You know, I haven't thought about it yet, probably for a resourceful person like me... What about you, Z? What are you going to do?

Zey lit a cigarette with difficulty and began, struggling to hold back sobs.

-I, I have nowhere to go... This world... it's already over... for me...

-Quiet! Zey…-Warrant Officer put his arm around the corporal.

-I know how you feel Z! I promise you, once we get out of here, I won't leave you alone!

-Wait…

-No, there's no use waiting for Z!

-Not that... Look!

Corporal Zey pointed to a suspicious, camouflaged individual slowly approaching the radio communications point.

-Son of a bitch! Zey, contact to the Post No. 44 immediately!

'Z' nervously tapped the radio channel as Tsoi moved into firing position.

-Hawk-2! This is Hippo-4! Some strange guy approaches your post. Camouflaged! Detain him until he shows his documents!

-This is Hawk-2, I understood, over.

The unknown, camouflaged man suddenly sank into the ground as if he had completely disappeared.

-Uh, what?

-This is Hawk-2, this is Hawk-2! Hippo-4, the suspect probably went down into the sewers, chase him?

-This is Warrant Coj, don't chase him yet. Report to the city's defense staff, preferably Captain Dean, and let him make the decision!

-Coj!

-What again?

-Fuck, we almost missed the conference because of this shit!

-Okay, turn it on quickly, I want to hear these words: 'We Horde actually got our asses kicked, so we're asking you on our knees for peace' - Coj laughed.

-You know it won't be like that, they're too... Hordian for that.

Corporal Zey connected the portable radio to the battery and pressed the button. Big time.

***

18:25

-…workforce provided by the Horde to help rebuild our kingdoms, and the end of the occupation of Dryl, and for all force captains active in the past thirty-seven years to stand trial for war crimes, you included.

A moment of tense silence.

-I'm afraid your terms are unacceptable…

All of Etheria suddenly froze, from the simple AKoB private on the Dryl Mountain Front to the ERF High Command.

Coj and Zey listened in unwritten fear. End of transmission, end of dreams,

end of delusion, end of... Etheria.

War Dances

The AHR headquarters quickly set out west, as far away from the dangerous, Rebel-infested area as possible. Catra impulsively pulled out her pad as soon as they hit the first Hordian checkpoint.

-General Atif and Colonel Grox to Commander Catra!

-General Atif reporting!

-Colonel Grox reporting!

-Start Operation Sun, over and out! Good luck…

Catra quickly switched the pad to another connection.

-Filips to Commander Catra, answer!

-Captain Ljubiša Filipović reports!

-Start Operation Sun immediately, you know what your people have to do...

-Yes Sir! Checking out!

Ljubiša had been waiting for this day for a long time, in fact almost as long as he had been waiting for the opportunity to take revenge on Huntara. His massive scar on the right side of his face silently confirmed this fact. Almost automatically, he took a radio from his backpack and turned on a special,

secret channel.

-Falcon-1? This is Falcon-5!

-Falcon-1 I'm reporting!

-Start 'AB' action, good luck Boško!

Fuck, another *Gorani* , aren't they extinct?

***

The atmosphere in the AKoB portable command center was so thick that it could easily be cut with a knife. The tent was filled with the omnipresent smell of anxiously burning cigarettes and the stench of officers sweating with terror.

Everyone was afraid to speak, everyone wanted to get out of there as quickly as possible and pretend it was just a bad dream. Everyone except fucking Colonel Morgan.

He started:

-General Juliett, I think that haste is advisable, but let's not exaggerate, the Horde is certainly not ready to take over our most important cities in the West

in the coming weeks. I believe that General Yenny's presence in Thaymor is not

a necessity for now!

-I'm making the decision, Morgan! I think you forgot who promoted you!

-Yes, I'm sorry!-Morgan bent slightly, hiding his grimace of contempt from the rest of the staff, contempt for the current AKoB command.

-General Yenna, you will leave for Thaymor immediately on a special plane,

we don't have many of them, but this will have to be enough.

I believe that Colonel Ypsilon is too inexperienced to hold the city, which is why you are needed there!

Morgan plunged into the conversation again.

-General, if I may! It's suicide! We have no control in the air!

-We have to take a risk, right?! Should he drive the car for several hours?! General, Yenna, please follow the order!

The machine is waiting beyond the clearing.

Yenna, very hungover and tired from the Conference, reluctantly saluted and moved towards the 'flying monster', or rather 'tiny monster', which could barely accommodate two people apart from the pilot.

Yenna had never flown before, and to be honest, she was terrified of this new means of transportation. Shaking the pilot's hand, closing the door, starting the engine, taking off from an uneven landing field, flying into the setting sun...

Morgan waved friendly at the machine.

Actually, it's better this way. Hordian pilots are very good at shooting at slow targets. Then I'll take that fucking alcoholic's place!

Delighted, he returned to the tent filled with smoke.

Nowhere to run

Zey, still shocked by the verdict, the death verdict,

given to the Etherians by the Etherians, looked nervously at his watch,

cocked his gun…

-Z, calm down! - Coj said harshly through his teeth, looking at the floor like a magpie looks at a bone.

-They have no right to attack now, I'm telling you!

Zeya didn't care about anything fucking Warrant Officer Coj said.

The clock slowly approached 7:30 p.m., 10 seconds, 7, 5, 2, 1…

Nothing, fucking nothing!

-Coj, I guess you were right, nothing is happening!

-I told you, they need a few more days.

A menacing howl from the Igman Hills, barely visible flames and slowly flying white streaks.

-Fuck, Coj! Down on the ground now!

The soldiers almost immediately fell down, covering their heads and eyes with their hands. The sound became louder and louder, so much so that you couldn't hear your own thoughts.

The first shell hit with a huge crash that shook the entire city center and damaged the hospital, the next explosion, close, getting closer.

Constant cannonades, constant earthquakes, constantly collapsing and burning buildings.

Finally, their building was hit too.

A loud explosion that almost sent them flying, a screech in their ears,

the taste of blood in their mouths. Another explosion, this time outside the area under artillery fire.

It is difficult to describe this view, even impossible.

Dozens of guns and rocket launchers continuously opened fire on the city with impunity for ten minutes.

Every building got hit or caught fire. The City Hospital and the local fuel depot burst into flames, completely consuming everyone inside.

The explosions in the East, sudden and unexpected, made it clear why strange, mysterious individuals had been roaming the city in recent hours.

Skyscrapers located to the west and center often collapsed or collapsed,

toppling another and another. Domino, it's a pity that it's full of people between the black and white blocks.

After ten minutes of hell, the longest ten minutes of their lives, there was complete, deathly silence. Well, not entirely, the constant sirens of fire trucks and military ambulances interrupted the silence before the storm.

Zey stood up and dusted himself off. The building was admittedly not in the best condition [this was evidenced by the building's tilt of several degrees and the construction bars sticking out everywhere], but well, damn, they survived this mess!

-Hey, Coj?

Zey looked at his companion, lying on the ruined sofa, with open eyes, full of terror.

-Coj?!

The corporal jumped a few steps to see what had happened. There was a heating tube embedded in the back of Coj's head that almost came out of his mouth.

I would be lying if I said that Zey was crying, breaking things, tearing at Coj's body, hoping that it would somehow resurrect him. I wish it were true.

In fact, Zey only closed his old friend's eyes and took away his walkie-talkie. This terrifying sight aroused almost no emotion in him. After the AHR tank had run over several of his men, after the bot had literally split his friend in half, the simple heating pipe in the back of the head was just a joke, just stupidity.

Zey took up firing positions, calmly waiting for the first AHR soldiers to appear in his viewfinder…

***

-Colonel Ypsilon, what the fuck are we doing? These fuckers are fucking on the west and northern side, that’s all we know!

Ypsilon, hunched and tired, sat at a small stool in the basement of the headquarters, still fighting back panic attacks.

He, a young officer with little battle experience, was sent as logistical aid,

not as the fucking commander of the city's defense.

-Captain Dean, please communicate with Brightmoon and Headquarters immediately, they must come to our aid!

Dean, slightly embarrassed by the commander-in-chief's attitude, said somewhat rudely:

-I would like to, Mr. Colonel, but I would like to remind you that these 'IDV' idiots blew up most of our radio communications

facilities, as well as the bridges over the rivers. I have sent messengers on horseback,

but they will probably arrive only in the morning...

We do have walkie-talkies, but they don't even cover the entire city, let alone half of Etheria!

Ypsilon slowly rose from his desk and turned his eyes towards Colonel Turpa, an old, bearded but spirited frontman.

-Colonel Turpa, you will immediately direct the 22nd and 23rd Brigade towards the West, and you will also take over command of the 21st Brigade, which is, hmmm, close to the City Park. Additionally, there are 2 Territorial Defense regiments in Lone Woods [Thaymor district]. We must send all our forces west!

"What if they attack from the north?" Dean replied sensibly.

-I doubt it, I think the full impact will come from the western, empty side. Colonel Turpa, please follow the order!

-Eh, yes Sir!

Turpa turned on the walkie-talkie, turning the knobs repeatedly to set the appropriate frequency.

-'Lion'! 'Rook'! Please answer! This is P-20! Please answer!

-Khzzzz! Khzzz!

Fuck.

-Mr. Colonel, there is no signal!

-Then…-Colonel Ypsilon stood over the desk, hesitating whether to say it.

-Then you have to climb the building next to it, from there... maybe you can make it...

-Yes Sir! *This is fucking suicide*

Turpa emerged from the basement, only to almost immediately be caught in the crossfire of large-caliber guns from AHR helicopters. He fell to the ground, pretending to be dead, and then ran into the destroyed, unlit staircase of a multi-story office building. Barely a step was enough to step on the body of a half-burnt soldier.

He was young, terrifyingly young.

Turpa decided not to stay here any longer, even though he saw more than one corpse. He ran madly and climbed to the roof of the ruin.

-'Lion', 'Rook', over! This is P-20! Answer!

-'Lion' reports, 'Rook' is here next to me!

-This is Colonel Turpa, I have orders for the 22nd and 23rd Brigade to move westwards immediately, understand? Colonel Weks, understood?

-Colonel, I barely made it downtown and those bastards are barely two hundred yards away! How the fuck am I supposed to hit the west?!

-I understand, then hold the position as long as possible!

Just as he ran out just as quickly, he returned just as quickly.

-Mr. Colonel!-Turpa began, out of breath.

-AHR forces are already in the Center! At least twenty AHR helicopters are flying over the city!

-Oh God... Throw everything we have to help 'Lion' immediately! That's an order!

Open fire on the helicopters with anti-aircraft guns!

-Almost all anti-aircraft guns were destroyed in the shelling...

-' Hornets'?

-A few in stock, most of them out of order…

Ypsilon got up to move it all away, to calm down.

-Gentlemen, if we don't hold the center until morning, it's over...

All civilian personnel must be evacuated east as quickly as possible,

and all troops in Thaymor must defend the center! Follow the order!

The rest of the staff obediently obeyed the order, saluted, and moved towards the setting sun, towards the place of their execution.

-Turpa, wait! I want you to stay here and help me coordinate the defense, understand?

-Yes, Sir!

Surfin Bird

The small plane, affectionately known as 'Stork', was slowly approaching the besieged city, despite the unfavorable conditions. Following the procedures of the Rebellion's remnant air force, the planes had to fly very low to avoid the ubiquitous, diabolically fast HH-2 and HH-3.

This seems like a reasonable procedure, but not when flying over Whispering Woods when there is light fog on the ground. The pilot had to show great skill to avoid tall trees and temple towers at the last moment.

-Madam General! We are forty kilometers from Thaymor, we will be there in half an hour tops! Fortunately, the fog is already falling, so it will be easier!

Yenna, barely able to hold back the vomiting caused by motion sickness, could only breathe a sigh of relief.

-Look, you can already see Thaymor! Oh my God…

-Oh fuck...

Their eyes saw a large column of black and gray smoke billowing from the former warehouses. Some rockets, some missiles, and some bombs were hitting the city almost constantly. The explosions, although somewhat quiet, were still audible even this far away. The plane climbed slightly upwards.

-We need to climb a bit here, the hills of Uruk are ahead of us, and then I'll try to land on the eastern edge of Thaymor!

The pilot pulled out the microphone from the radio and simultaneously punched in a frequency of the city airstrip.

-This is AF-2! Tu-AF-2! Please answer! I need permission to land!

-Khzz, khzz!

-Ehh, no comments, I'll try later...

The flight for the next ten minutes was quite uneventful, apart from missing the mountain walls by centimeters twice.

-Madam General! We have a problem, a big fucking problem! - You could hear the terror in the pilot's voice.

-What is it?!-Yenna looked deeply into the sky, at 11 o'clock.

The pilot's answer was not needed.

Two menacing, sleek HH-3 helicopters were approaching inexorably.

-Fuck, what are we doing?

-Madam General, I have to land here, we have no defensive weapons...

-How far to Thaymor?

-Over 15 kilometers…

Their speculations were interrupted by a sudden burst from the helicopter. A series towards them.

-Alright fuck, land here!

-Umm, we have a problem!

-What is it again?

The elevator is almost unresponsive!

The plane began to dive more and more sharply towards the ground. Another series with HH-3, this time it ended with breaking the rear window and 'only' igniting the fuel tank.

A terrifying alarm sounded on the plane.

200 meters, 150, 100, 80, 60, 30…

Terrain, Pull up! Pull up! Pull up!

At the last moment, the pilot leveled out to ground level, only to crash

with full force into the tree with the right, already burning wing of the plane.

The plane made a pirouette and hit hard ground…

Dark Magic

The village of Frumor, temporary command point of the 301st and 103rd Brigades, 20:00

The sun had almost descended from the sky when Captain Ljubiša Filipović,

a bit tired from the constant preparations, entered the command and communications tent.

This constant waiting was giving him an incredible headache. He sits here,

just coordinating artillery fire, while his brother claims victory over Thaymor.

With a bored, bored gesture, he picked up the pad and started the call:

-Falcon-4, are you okay? Boško, are you there?

A few seconds of deafening silence, heralding the worst, the sudden sound of receiving a message.

-This is Falcon-4, reporting!

- How is your situation?

-No fatalities, two slightly injured, everyone has already been evacuated behind the front line.

Phew, at least that much!

-Perfect, report back when you reach the nearest AHR unit,

it should be in Kijevo, I'm sending you the location.

-Roger that, Captain. Ljubo..

-Da? [Yes?]

-Želim ti puno sreće, dragi prijatelju! [Good luck my friend!]

-Ako tebe! Neka Bog te čuva! [To you! May God protect you!]

The conversation ended and Ljubo received strange looks from the staff officers. Ah, this language, it sounds like a hornet's nest!

Filipović reached for his leather jacket, dating back to his collaboration with Tung Lashor. He put his hand in for a pack of cigarettes lying deep inside

in the right pocket…

The pad began to buzz loudly, to quote the classic, 'it rang as if it wanted to be answered'. The captain lit a cigarette and turned on the video call.

Catra appeared on the screen, obviously... happy, a rare sight!

-Captain Ljubo, Atif's troops have occupied Western Thaymor, and all defenders are being directed to defend this sector. In 15 minutes I want to see your bots moving in the Center! Understood?

-Yes, Commander Catra!

The screen went blank and Ljubo fell into a state of near ecstasy.

After a few days in the headquarters, anyone, especially the commander of the sabotage and reconnaissance unit, could go crazy.

Without thinking, he reached for the field phone.

-Connect with the command of the 103rd Brigade! Hello, Colonel Griv?

-Yes captain Filipović?

-Start attacking the enemy position!

Even through the receiver, the Colonel's quiet cry of satisfaction could be heard.

-Yes, I'm starting to do it!

Ljubiša stood up from the phone, looking around. He didn't have to say anything, his men had already stood up and taken up fighting positions.

He sprinted out of the tent, trying to get into position before his soldiers moved without him. Stopping in a meadow to catch his breath, he saw a huge number of bots and IFVs 50 meters away, hundreds of soldiers, just waiting for his signal. Without thinking, he turned on the walkie-talkie.

-This is Captain Ljubiša Filipović, to all units, begin the attack!

Brave *Gorani* ran into the command boat at a speed, being one of the first to set off. The avalanche of vehicles, bots, and soldiers

set off, proudly at first, slowly, stately, gradually gaining momentum as they rolled down the hills.

Ljubiša ordered to open fire, watching as his men and bots reduced the city center to a pile of rubble. It's a hospital, it's another residential building, everything started to collapse.

The first shots of snipers and machine guns from AKoB in their direction,

the first wounded and... killed.

-Attention snipers! Quick, hide the fuck away!

He jumped out of the vehicle and ran to the other soldiers nestling in the drainage ditch, grabbing his assault rifle.

He aimed and shot several grams of lead into the heads of the machine gun crew. The old H2 heavy machine gun that flooded the Horde trenches with walls of lead has fallen silent forever.

New generation heavy combat bots passed right above their heads, wreaking havoc on the Rebel ranks.

Ljubo looked at the slowly opening road to the center, at the terrified AKoB guards running south in panic.

-Quick, Lieutenant Marko! Follow me! For the Horde. For *Gorani* !

The screams of dozens of officers echoed through Hordian positions.

'Follow me, attack! For the Horde! For Free Etheria!'

Waves of experienced front liners from the 301st Brigade poured out of the trenches, and dozens of vehicles, shelling the city from a safe distance,

followed the tsunami of soldiers to support the infantry.

'This is where the fun begins'

Ljubo thought, not very original.

At the Dangerous Line

Not yet, not yet, now!

Zey saw in the scope of his rifle a soldier running through the field without

a helmet and with a characteristic red headband.

An idiot!

Shot.

The AHR soldier fell to the ground, bleeding from his torn neck.

Fuck that he was barely 20 years old, fuck that he had someone who loved him, fuck that it was his first major mission. Zey, once a pacifist, has learned to simply ignore it.

The statement of the officer in charge during the training stuck in his head:

'They will have no mercy on you! Why should you show mercy to them?!'

A shot at the window next to his position snapped him out of his slight lethargy. He immediately ran up the floor and took up position again.

He measured the moment with his sniper rifle. The seconds passed.

He saw a lieutenant without an eye emerging from behind the bots, with a gun in his right hand.

Shot. Down. Another one was killed.

Change of position, another shot.

An old, bearded corporal carrying a heavy machine gun was hit in the stomach, but the bullet was taken away. He bent over and began to slowly crawl towards the paramedics.

'They will have no mercy on you! Why should you show mercy to them?!'

So why the fuck don't I have the strength to shoot him?

The distraction cost Corporal Zey a lot.

A distant bang, a burning sensation in the collarbone. The laser shot through the bone, leaving only a burnt hole behind.

Zey groaned in pain.

By force of will, he slowly raised the gun and fired at the shooter, who was close enough to blow our corporal's head off.

Shot. Overload. Shot.

The bullet hit the unknown AHR soldier directly in the head, shattering his helmet visor. Streams of blood gushed in all directions, covering the entire helmet with red goo. The second Hordian writhed in pain, hit in the chest. Shot.

The reduced fare is over, motherfuckers!

The H-90 tank, powerful with composite armor and a laser cannon, approached dangerously. He pointed the barrel at Zey's outpost.

The corporal dropped his weapon almost immediately and ran as far as he could to avoid, but what?

Wasn't I looking for death? So why am I running away from her like a coward now?

A bang, a powerful shot of a laser charge. The bullet hit the load-bearing wall perfectly, tearing it completely apart. The block began to tip over, falling faster and faster towards the ground.

So it's over, already?!

Instinctively, 'Z' covered his head with his hands and hunched his legs, hoping that by some miracle he would survive.

A sudden impact with a neighboring building, then with the ground.

Hitting your head on a support beam, losing consciousness...

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-Captain, it's here!

-Oh, nice 'ptica'! Is alive?

-Yeah, just unconscious.

-Okay, take him out and give him to the next ones!

Zey began to blink, slowly gaining some sense.

-Where…where am I? Who are you?

-Commander of the 189th Special Sabotage and Reconnaissance Unit 'IDV', Captain Ljubiša Filipović, I'm very pleased!- He said with a full, mocking smile.

-And you, what's your name? Was there anyone here with you?

-Fuck off, you Horde scumbag!- Zey growled through his teeth.

-Hardy bitch! You, your name is Span?

-Yes, Captain!

-So Span, you're going to tie this bird up and take it to the POW camp, understood? If you try to resist, shoot him!

-Yes, Mr. Captain!

Zey watched as the burly sergeant tied his hands behind his back and looked at him with utter contempt.

I was supposed to be a hero, I was supposed to shoot a hundred dicks like him, I was supposed to die here at the outpost as a hero, and what?!

Now I'll spend the rest of my life in a cobalt mine...

-Get up, whore!

-I can't feel my legs...-said the corporal dismissively.

Filipović, the fucking ex-gangster, of course, had to show a little of his hidden sadism. He was supposed to continue attacking, but well, two minutes and he's back. Typical Tung Lashor man.

-Wait, I'll help you!- Filipović pulled out an old pistol from his holster, remembering the times when Horde was just Hordak's ruined ship.

Without thinking, he reloaded and shot the prisoner in the foot.

A groan full of pain, full of helplessness...

-What, can you go now?

Do I still need to perform surgery on the other leg?!

Zey said nothing more, only blushed with shame and humiliation.

He stood up with great difficulty, barely moving his right, shot leg.

-Move, Rebel whore!-Sergeant Span pushed him so hard that he almost knocked him to the ground.

-Sergeant Span! After returning the prisoner, return to your position in sector 6. Understood?

-Yes, Captain!

Ljubo, together with fifty men and several tanks, ran into the city,

disappearing into the fog caused by numerous fires.

-Listen to me carefully, 'Rebel', you've already lost! Look, your dreams are burning, your wishes of power are burning! Look, motherfucker!

[the sergeant grabbed Zey by the neck, forcing him to look at the suffering of the city, at the fires, at the bodies of his brothers, at the destroyed graves,

graves of civilians and defenders of the city who did not survive the fall of Thaymor].

I shouldn't hide from this missile…

City Defense Headquarters, 8:50 p.m

The Headquarters building, already heavily damaged by AHR artillery fire,

was almost empty. Almost. Messengers constantly appeared in the building to provide information to individual commanders of regiments and battalions.

Turpa and Ypsilon were nervously discussing over the desk with a tactical map, what to do, where to send the 18th Light Infantry Battalion, where to send the 4th Territorial Guard Regiment, and how to evacuate the 345th Logistics Regiment. The discussion was interrupted only by the sounds of bullets,

which regularly shook the headquarters.

Colonel Weks, winded and wounded in the head, ran into the almost empty command center. His facial expression said it all.

-Mr. Colonel, these bastards have driven a wedge into the city center,

the City Park and the Avenue are pure hell!

-What about the 22nd and 23rd Brigades? -Ypsilon tried to hide his horror by avoiding the topic.

-The 22nd Brigade is surrounded, they can't break through! My 23 got hit pretty bad too, but we managed to get her back here! At least part of…

-The condition of the 21st Brigade?! What's happening to Dean?!

-Turpa exclaimed.

Weks looked down and drank a full, large glass of vodka on a golden tray.

With this, the AKoB soldiers intended to welcome Peace.

-21st Light Infantry Brigade…evaporated under bots and lasers. I only gathered a few dozen people from the entire Brigade...

-Where the fuck is Yenna!-Ypsilon showed the first symptoms of hysteria.

-A plane crashed over the hills, they reported from point 'Osa-3'.

-Fuck!

There was complete silence, complete! The officers looked from the map to each other. This awkward moment was interrupted forcefully by a young private who was out of breath.

-Private Treek reporting, oh Gods... Wait a minute, let me catch my breath...

-Go on, speak!-Turpa drawled.

-Catra's forces are striking from the east and north. They shot all the messengers, only I managed to...

-Enough! What is the enemy's strength?

-At least 3 brigades have already taken positions near the city!

Another moment of silence.

Colonel Turpa finally couldn't stand it anymore.

-Mr. Colonel, we only have about two of the five brigades left,

they have a numerical and equipment advantage several times!

The roar of guns, this time from the eastern side, made it clear that this was not the nonsense of a confused private.

-So what do you propose...-Ypsilon lost all will to fight.

-Gather all soldiers who can carry weapons and retreat to Halmor or Drumar,

it doesn't matter, we must flee south!

-Juliett and Morgan won't forgive us for this! General Yenna…

-Finally understand that she's gone, they won't help us either! If you want to see Brightmoon, Alwyn, and Mastesia again in your life, we have to get the fuck out of here!

Ypsilon stood over the tray, took two glasses, and drank the first one, then the second one.

A moment of silence, well, conventional silence.

Constant explosions are not a state of absolute silence.

-You're right, gather the most efficient soldiers, and we'll send them as messengers. They are to give the order that everyone should evacuate south.

We too.

Ypsilon stood in the doorframe, leaning heavily on it. AHR tanks were visible closer and closer, with hundreds of explosions, and hundreds of corpses.

-Gentlemen, we have lost... Let's get out of here.

For Whom the Bell Tolls

Town Center, while before

‘The AHR forces attacking from the west did a titanic job. The most elite units of the Fifth Corps attacked the forces of evil, driving them out of the western part of the city. From the north and north-east, elite troops of the Third Corps entered the Center, destroying the defense lines of the so-called AKoB…'

The radio set up in the building recently occupied by AKoB was blaring at full volume.

-Turn that shit off, Lieutenant Ratko!-Ljubo growled through his teeth.

-Yes, Captain!

Two quick shots, the radio went silent forever.

The AHR soldiers moved slowly, keeping in mind that every building could be occupied by some AKoB fanatics. The full-scale attack towards Main Avenue and the Park was a complete success.

New generation bots acted as decoys paving the way.

Whatever the bot didn't shoot, the old frontline or tanker did.

Captain Ljubo's group [Group D], now numbering just over a hundred men, was moving eastward to complete the encirclement of units locked in combat with his adoptive brother's forces. A group of 20 soldiers, protected from the front by a dozen or so bots, quickly ran through a dangerous, long street, locating themselves in the ruins of several buildings.

-Sir, Captain, I think it's clean...

-Shhh. Give me some rod and a helmet…

The unnamed soldier obediently obeyed the order,

giving Gorani his helmet and an almost two-meter-long steel rod.

Without much thought, Filipović put his helmet on the pole and put it out into the street.

Shot straight in the helmet.

-Lieutenant, send bots for a frontal attack, fifteen of you, follow me!

Don't leave me even for a step! Understood?

-Yes Sir!

-Lieutenant, you will hold this post until Catra's forces arrive, understood?

Give us one tank for cover too!

-Yes Sir!

A moment of silence, more sniper shots.

Large 2B-x-type bots jumped out from around the corner of the street, only for one of them to be taken out almost immediately by an artillery shell. The remaining four continued to brew, turning the other end of the street into

a living hell.

Some distance away, a unit of 16 crazy soldiers followed them, ready for anything. Making their way through small gardens and fences, they came within shooting distance.

A burst from Ljubiša's HAR75, further shots from the rifles of other masked soldiers. A few so-called 'pigeonmen' [a slang term for snipers] fell from several series to the ground. The cannon that had so easily turned the bot into a pile of iron a moment ago was now itself reduced to scrap.

Ljubo reached for the pad.

-Lieutenant Marko, the street is clear!

-Roger that, Catra's troops have just arrived!

-Finally, I thought they were going to crush us, heh!

-Those pussies? They can't even shoot a pigeon!

-So much pussy that I lost over thirty men! Don't underestimate the enemy!

Join us!

-Yes Sir!

As soon as Ljubo put down the pad, a new conversation appeared on the screen.

Atif.

Without hesitation, the captain answered the call.

-Greetings Ljubo, kakva je situacija u centra grada?

[Hello Ljubo, how is the situation in the city center?]

-Sve je u redu, ljudi moji, pardon vaši ljudi, okoirali su bolnicu, gradski park

i aveniju. Očito je Catra već ušla u grad.

[Everything is fine, my people, sorry, your people, they have occupied the hospital, the city park, and the avenue. Catra has already entered the city].

-Good, now I remember that talking in Gorani is prohibited on the link...

-It's fucking discrimination and don't tell me it's not!

-Okay, shut your mouth. I have better information. The 22nd Brigade surrendered, they ran out of ammunition hahaha!

-Really, they only had ammunition for an hour of fighting, no kidding!

-No, they're just a bit bad at camouflaging their ammo stash...

-Wait, I've got Catra on line, we'll talk later.

Doviđenja Atif!

-Adios, you piece of shit!

-Sergeant, are they really talking to each other like that? He's a general after all...

-It looks like you're new, Drk. How do you think I talk to my brother?! And he's a fucking colonel!

-Yeah, I think he's a colonel on Beast Island!

-Shut up, Fin, or I'll put some lead in your eye socket!

-Shut your mouth! I've got Catra on the line!

-Yes, Captain!

Ljubo entered the conversation slowly, slightly afraid of the commander-in-chief's reaction.

-Captain Ljubiša Filipović reporting!

-Ljubo, how is the situation in the center? What losses?

-At least 36 dead, over 90 injured, several missing. 3 tanks were destroyed, as well as several dozen bots. We occupied the park, the hospital, and the avenue, we also cut off the 22nd Brigade and part of the 23rd from the rest of the AKoB units, they had just surrendered!

-Okay, Atif already told me. Send your men south to push all the rebels out of Thaymor, and Grox will deal with them there. We have just occupied the abandoned headquarters, everything is going according to plan!

After dealing with them, you will hand over the command to Lonnie and return to Dryl.

-Are you sure we won't be needed in Halmor?

-That's an order! I finished!

-Eh, yes Commander Catra!

The conversation ended.

Sometimes I regret that I supported Catra and not Callix, but on the other hand...

With Callix at the helm, I would have been a passenger on the first trip to Beast Island a long time ago…

Run to the hills

Officers, privates, generals, conscripts, volunteers, medics.

Everyone was running away from the Horde's tank fight at a mad pace.

Soldiers threw away backpacks, food rations, and supply wagons

valuable backpacks with medicines and ammunition. Anything to retreat south as quickly as possible, at least to Halmor. Morale collapsed completely,

both among the higher ranks and among the mere 'cannon fodder'.

-Colonel Turpa, how many men do we have? -Ypsilon said resignedly.

-Mr. Colonel, about 2,900, maybe three thousand.

-Any heavy weapon?

-We managed to save only two old armored vehicles.

Colonel, it doesn't matter, at least we got away!

Although it is quite strange that they are not chasing us, very strange...

The march, or rather escape, took place in a gloomy atmosphere. AHR may have given up on direct attacks, but it continued to bombard the escapees' positions with helicopters.

Turpa looked at his watch, 10:30 p.m.

Seriously, we lost a city defended for months in three hours?!

Several scouts came running from above a hill that was supposed to protect against artillery fire.

-Mr. Colonel!

-What is?!

-Tanks from the south, lots of tanks! Lots of bots! They have Horde marks!

-Turpa, what the fuck is going on here?!

-I don't fucking know! How many are there, soldier?

-What...at least 2nd Brigade.

-This is the end of Turpa...-Ypsilon pulled out his gun and pressed the trigger. Blood and brain blurred across the patch covered with dew.

Turpa was not indifferent to this act.

-Wex, you take command now. Please make an act of surrender...

-Yes Sir…

Turpa pulled the gun from the city defense commander's hand, still warm. Without thinking much, he put it to his temple. *Clank*

-Colonel, what are we doing?!

-Tell everyone to drop their weapons...

-We surrender?! And the princesses, and the Rebellion?!

-What princesses, son, do you see them here? They don't care about us...

I have about 200 tanks in front of me and behind me, several hundred bots,

and I don't have any cannon! Should I send you to be mowed down by machine guns? Tell everyone that we are surrendering, I will go on a delegation to Thaymor, I will surrender there...

-Yes, sir…

***

Weks took a white sheet to serve as a symbol of surrender. A humiliated, older, mustachioed general was going to meet the new rulers of the city.

- You, granny, aren't you lost, hehe? - A tall, bald, young soldier from the 505th Brigade approached him with an HSG96 aimed.

-As you can see, I am an officer and you are a private. I expect some respect.

-And, as you can see, I have it right here! In my ass! I don't give a damn Rebel scumbag!

Say goodbye to your flea life, you bastard!

-What's going on here?!-A tall general stood next to the private: Atif Halasimović.

-Mr. Gen… Gen... General. I caught an AKoB officer, he says he's a colonel.

-You didn't catch me, son. I have surrendered myself to you!

Atif, despite his suspicions that the Rebel side would want to negotiate,

was thoroughly surprised by this act of courage. The courage that Atif always appreciated.

In a serious tone, he said:

-Mr. Colonel, I am General of Division Atif Halasimović.

What does Mr. Colonel want from us? And what is Colonel's name?

-My name is Colonel Weks, I am the current commander of the defense of Thaymor. Our situation turned dramatic in just a few hours. To prevent further bloodshed, I am ready to sign the act of surrender of my units...

-I understand, Colonel, please follow me. And you! [Here he pointed to the embarrassed private] Next time, keep your mouth shut!

-Yes, sir!

The officers walked together, two warriors who sent their sons to fight to the death. They didn't say a word to each other the entire way.

After a short hike, the two soldiers entered the former headquarters building, already adapted to the role of the headquarters of the Fifth AHR Corps.

They went to the top floor.

In the command room, so recently abandoned, in the place of the commander of the city's defense, She sat.

-Commander Catra…

-Colonel Weks. What, surprised by Grox's attack?

Weks looked down.

-Commander Catra, I am ready to sign the act of unconditional surrender of my troops who...

-Oh my gosh, [Catra laughed ironically] do you really think that means anything? These formalities? Your soldiers are already on their way to the Fright Zone in trucks. And you... Soon you will join them... Handcuff him!

This is how dreams of the Rebellion's power end, Grandpa!

Bring the prisoner out!

-Yes, Commander Catra!

-And you, Atif... You can hand over your command of the Force to Captain Lonnie. Good job. Now get out, you are needed at Dryl and so are your people.

-Yes Commander Catra…

Hordak has only got one ball

Road to the Fright Zone, two days later

Zey was shocked, even transfixed, by the amount of loss.

The rebellion lost 12,000 soldiers, hundreds of guns and an important city.

At what cost? 450 AHR soldiers killed, a dozen tanks, several hundred bots?

The city defended itself for only a few hours…

-Move, you bastard!-The big guard waved his energy baton in front of Zey.

The corporal said nothing more, trying to quicken his pace despite his shot

in the right leg. The column of prisoners to which Zey belonged was several hundred meters long.

The ragged, wounded, hungry, and thirsty AKoB soldiers were herded like sheep to the slaughter.

Even though he lost, Zey didn't feel like he had lost his enthusiasm.

On the contrary, he felt it much more strongly than during the earlier battles for Thaymor.

Finally, concerned about his inability to resist, he began to sing a song.

At least this way he can get back at those Horde motherfuckers.

Hordak has only got one ball,

Grizzlor has two but very small,

Cobalt has rather sim'lar,

But poor old Callix has no balls at all

At first, he sang alone, quietly, and shyly, then others joined in,

sometimes whistling, sometimes singing loudly. Eventually,

the entire column began to openly mock the former leader of the Horde.

Hordak has only got one ball,

Grizzlor has two but very small,

Cobalt has rather sim'lar,

But poor old Callix has no balls at all

Catra has five or six, I guess...

The all-terrain carrying the commander of the punishment convoy heading to the Fright Zone screeched to a halt.

-Shut the fuck up! Shut your mouths, you Rebel trash!

But no one listened to him. The crowd of prisoners began to sing again.

Hordak has only got one ball,

Grizzlor has two but very small,

Cobalt has rather sim'lar,

But poor old Callix has no balls at all

Catra has five or six...

-Sergeant, get your boys ready! You know what you have to do!

-Yes Sir!

AHR soldiers surrounded the column, aiming their weapons. Despite this,

the captives did not stop singing...

The column commander shouted loudly, almost so loudly that he seemed to lose his voice.

-Fire!!!

ERF General Staff, Brightmoon

May 22, '92

-Colonel Morgan, due to the death of General Yenna, and due to the massive losses inflicted by the Horde, I appoint you as my representative and right-hand man. Starting today, you take command of all units in Whispering Woods and Plumeria. You are simultaneously appointed as a Second Class General. Congratulations and good luck!

-Thank you, General Juliett.

'This is where the fun begins'

When will this finally end?!

End Notes

So finally, Part Two.
Some of you may have noticed that most scenes have a separate title, a song title, that has a more or less similar meaning.
Additionally, there are three reworked songs in this short story, here's the list:
-Just don't tell mum I'm in Chechnya (reworked and cut);
-Light Flashes in the Dark (reworked and cut);
-H***** has only got one ball (reworked);
-War Dances [Tańce Wojenne]-Polish song made by Kazik (scene title);
-Nowhere to Run [Martha Reeves and the Vandellas] (title);
-Surfin Bird [The Trashmen] (title);
-Dark Magic [Чёрная Магия]-Russian song made by Sektor Gaza (title);
-At the Dangerous Line [У Опасной Черты]-Soviet Afgan song made by Blue Berets (title);
-For Whom the Bell Tolls [Metallica] (title);
-Run to the Hills [ACDC] (title);

Abbreviations that may not be understood:
HSG96-[the newest Hordian submachine gun, used only in 505th and 510th Brigade in laser version] (inspired by Mini-Beryl);
HAR75- [most common assault rifle in Horde, gunpowder and laser versions, still in use every Corpse] (inspired by Zastava M70);
H2-[very popular heavy machine gun, still in every Corps, gunpowder and laser versions] (inspired by legendary M2 Browning :P);
M-53 “Lizard”-[very obsolete, but still most common SPAAG in AHR, due to his possibility of being used as infantry support vehicle, artillery, and anti-tank cannon, in service in every Corps, in PTG and ERF] (Inspired by my beloved, legendary Praga M-53 Jesterka :D);
H90 tank-Horde Third Generation Main Battle Tank

[modernization of H84 from ‘92, equipped with levitation sensors, additional gun stabilization, better composite armor, and only a laser cannon, the same as in the H84. Used only by the Fifth Corps, it is intended to replace the slowly aging H84 in the future. Often called "Cobalt", after the commander of the First Corps.

AHR-Army of the Horde Republic
AKoB-Army of the Kingdom of Brightmoon
ERF-Etherian Rebel Forces (the combined forces of all the armed forces of the countries in the war against the Horde);

If you would like to learn something about the plot or just talk, visit my DC :D
Whoever and whenever is reading this, have a nice day

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